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Research on the moral slippery slope risk of unethical pro-organizational behavior and its mechanism: a moderated mediation model

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Abstract
In recent years, many employees have engaged in unethical pro-organizational behavior (UPB) – behavior that is contrary to the norms of society and ethical codes and that aims to benefit employees' organizations, thereby harming external stakeholder interests. Numerous studies have investigated the antecedents of and formation process underlying UPB, but scholars have paid less attention to the potential moral "slippery slope" effects of this behavior. Based on the framework of social cognitive theory, our research examines the process by which employees' UPB influences their individual workplace cheating behaviors at the individual level, concentrating on the mediating effect of moral disengagement and exploring the influence of psychological entitlement as a moderator. A longitudinal questionnaire study featuring 257 participants reveals that employees' UPB has a significantly positive impact on their workplace cheating behaviors. Furthermore, the association between employees' UPB and workplace cheating behaviors is mediated by moral disengagement, and the positive correlation between UPB and moral disengagement can be strengthened by psychological entitlement. Moreover, the mediating role of moral disengagement in the association between UPB and workplace cheating behaviors can be positively moderated by psychological entitlement. This research contributes to the literature on how UPB affects employees' cognition and behaviors and has practical implications for managers seeking to inhibit such unethical acts.

Keywords Social cognitive theory · Unethical pro-organizational behavior · Moral disengagement · Psychological entitlement · Workplace cheating behavior

Introduction

In the context of modern business development, problems with unethical behavior in companies and enterprises have become widespread. As research on this topic has progressed, scholars have come to recognize that the perspective of self-interest cannot by itself adequately explain the nature of behavioral immorality in business contexts (Umphress et al., 2010). Due to the introduction of the notion of unethical pro-organization behavior (UPB) by Umphress et al. (2010), researchers obtained an enhanced ability to understand immoral activity that is prompted by benevolent intentions (Mishra et al., 2021). UPB is defined as conduct on the part of employees that violates social and ethical norms with the goal of benefitting their company or fellow team members rather than the pursuit of selfish motives (Umphress & Bingham, 2011). To date, scholars have defined a wide range of notable antecedents that induce UPB at the individual, team, and organizational levels, including personal

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traits, such as Machiavellianism (Castille et al., 2016); various leadership practices, such as bottom-line leadership and unethical leadership (Babalola et al., 2020; Nosrati et al., 2023); and a positive relationship with the organization, including employee identification with the organization (Chen et al., 2016). These research streams have focused on the mechanism that triggers UPB from the perspectives of social exchange, social cognition, and social identity. In particular, social cognition is an influential explanatory mechanism for the process of unethical behavior formation and deterioration in organizational settings, and moral disengagement is a critical cognitive element in this process (Mishra et al., 2021).

Although UPB has become commonplace in the business world and many studies of the antecedents of such behaviors have been conducted (Mo et al., 2022), uncertainty concerning how UPB influences employees' subsequent cognitions and behaviors represents a critical gap in related research (Liao et al., 2023). Therefore, scholars have gradually shifted their attention to the consequences of UPB, suggesting that UPB could have negative impacts on employees' subsequent work behaviors, engagement, and performance (Hao et al., 2023; Xu et al., 2023). However, these previous studies are insufficient to support a full understanding UPB's nomological network and nature; academics still know little about the work behaviors that may emerge after UPB (Liao et al., 2023), and a key question in this context pertains to whether UPB degenerates into more destructive self-interested unethical behavior (Anderson et al., 2023). Given the camouflaged "pro-organizational" character of this conduct, the potentially destructive losses caused by its unethical nature might be ignored. Nevertheless, over time, UPB inevitably results in reputational damage to an organization and financial costs due to pecuniary penalties. In the case of the financial falsification scandal of Luckin Coffee, the company in question was eventually suspended from the Nasdaq index and paid a sizable fine (Zhang et al., 2022). Given the destructive impact of UPB on an organization, exploring whether UPB triggers reactions on the part of employees themselves, which in turn hinder the functioning of the organization, is crucial. In particular, the potential moral "slippery slope" effect of UPB requires further investigation, including with regard to (1) its negative consequences for employees and the organization and (2) the boundary conditions and mediation mechanisms associated with this process.

To address the aforementioned limitations of previous research, we introduce the perspective of social cognition to explore how and when UPB motivates employees to exhibit a psychological state of "moral slipperiness" and shapes their workplace behaviors. Drawing on social cognitive theory, one reason for which people behave unethically is that certain cognitive processes loosen the ethical constraints on their behaviors, and people continually use their previous behavior as a reference (Bandura, 1991). Individuals' tend to engage in more cheating behaviors when the outcome of their dishonesty may benefit another person or organization (Gino et al., 2013). Accordingly, we propose that employees' UPB is a form of cheating that benefits the organization for a short period of time and is likely to stimulate individuals' self-serving or self-protective cheating behavior, thereby jeopardizing the interests of the organization. Due to the moral slippery slope effect of UPB, the unethical nature of UPB represents the initial stimulus in the collapse of the individual's self-moral schema, as the individual's good intentions aimed at helping the organization blur the boundaries of ethical standards (Zhang et al., 2022). The constraints imposed by the moral code on the individual's behavior are thus weakened, resulting in unethical behaviors. More precisely, when employees cheat customers or hide defects to further the interests of the organization without regard to social norms and moral codes, ethical self-regulation is also compromised. An erosion of the power of self-restraint thus occurs, and employees may then cheat their colleagues or leaders to satisfy their own self-interest with regard to UPB, leading to higher overall levels of employee cheating and scamming within an organization. In daily work scenarios, employees more frequently commit fraud, lie, and engage in other forms of deception to advance their own interests (Mitchell et al., 2018). These types of immoral conduct are categorized as workplace cheating behaviors (Shu et al., 2011). The selfishness exhibited by such behaviors is the opposite of pro-organizational traits, thus highlighting the slippery slope leading from the goal of contributing to the organization to the pursuit of self-interest, and this behavior is easily motivated by the cognitive mechanism associated with UPB (Chen et al., 2022). Therefore, workplace cheating behavior is used to represent self-serving deception.

The immorality of UPB may cause severe fluctuations in employees' emotions and induce cognitive dissonance (Umphress & Bingham, 2011). Individuals rationalize these unethical behaviors and reconstruct their cognitions to achieve cognitive equilibrium—a process which is known as neutralization (Umphress & Bingham, 2011). Social cognitive theory has outlined the psychosocial mechanisms underlying this process of neutralization, in which context detrimental conduct is selectively disengaged from moral self-sanctions, allowing people to engage in harmful behaviors while remaining at peace with themselves (Zsolnai, 2016); this situation results in the emergence of a cognitive strategy of moral disengagement. Due to a variety of loose moral cognitive processes, moral disengagement impairs individuals' moral self-discipline and self-control, causing people to behave in more unethical ways (e.g., by engaging in workplace cheating behavior) without experiencing feelings of guilt. Therefore, based on the explanatory framework of social cognitive theory, we believe that after engaging

in UPB, employees rationalize their own subsequent self-serving or cheating behavior via the neutralization of moral disengagement.

To explore the conditions under which UPB indirectly influences employees' cheating behavior via a stronger or weaker method in further detail, our study introduces a variable that describes individual differences to moderate this moral slippery slope effect: psychological entitlement. That is, not all employees engage in workplace cheating behavior after UPB because the extent to which individuals' moral self-regulation is eroded as a result of UPB is affected by employees' various levels of psychological entitlement. Specifically, when employees' moral disengagement is combined with high psychological entitlement, we contend that they tend to form pervasive beliefs that lead them to feel entitled to preferential treatment or reciprocation (Campbell et al., 2004); furthermore, a mentality of inflated privilege fuels the self-serving motivation of such individuals and enables employees to act unethically in pursuit of selfish gains. Consequently, we consider psychological entitlement to be an essential boundary condition influencing the outcomes of UPB such that workers with a strong sense of entitlement are more inclined to act unethically to satisfy their self-interested desires.

This study's objective is to explore the impact of UPB on employees' self-interested conduct (i.e., workplace cheating) from the perspective of social cognitive theory. This study makes several contributions to our understanding of UPB. First, the antecedents and predisposing factors associated with UPB have been the focus of numerous studies (Mishra et al., 2021); nevertheless, we investigate the impact of the cognitive and behavioral repercussions of UPB from the perspective of social cognitive theory, thus responding to calls for research on behavioral outcomes (Chen et al., 2022; Wang et al., 2021a, b). Our analysis of the relationship between UPB and employees' workplace cheating behavior enriches the nomological network of UPB and highlights the detrimental impact of this behavior, which can result in the deterioration of moral self-discipline and ultimately lead to deviant behavior. Second, this study contributes to the ethics literature by focusing on the mediating role of moral disengagement in the relationship between employees' UPB and cheating behavior. Moral disengagement is the critical psychological and cognitive process that encourages employees to continue to engage in misconduct in work scenarios after they have committed unethical behavior (Zhang et al., 2022). In light of this argument and the insights of social cognitive theory, the current research proposes to identify moral disengagement as a potential mediator in this context, thereby opening the "black box" of the ability of UPB to encourage employees to engage in cheating at work. Third, by taking into account the relevant differences among individuals, this study further investigates the people for whom the effects of UPB are more pronounced (Keem et al., 2018). Our understanding of "when" UPB has a moral slippage effect is deepened by an examination of the moderating effect of psychological entitlement on the indirect relationship between UPB and employees' cheating behavior through moral disengagement. To date, no studies have focused on psychological entitlement as a boundary condition with regard to the impact of UPB on individuals' self-interested unethical behavior.

Theoretical background and hypothesis development

Social cognitive theory

Bandura's (1989) social cognitive theory posits that three factors affect human activity, namely, personal behavior, individual cognition and trait factors, and external environment, that persons make a causal contribution to their motives and behavior. In other words, individuals memorize a sequence of events, and their past behavior is frequently utilized as a benchmark for their subsequent actions (Bandura, 1991). Significantly, based on the notion of social cognition, a system of self-regulation and monitoring that is internal to individuals emerges, such that most people have established moral self-standards for their behavior (Bandura et al., 1996). Individuals are inclined to behave in morally correct ways in their moral decision-making when this moral self-regulatory system is operating effectively. However, once this self-monitoring mechanism is undermined, the self-regulatory norms of morality become less restrictive, leading to the emergence of unethical behavior—a phenomenon which is known as moral disengagement (Bandura, 1999).

Social cognitive theory serves as the theoretical basis for the concept of moral disengagement (Bandura, 1999; Bandura et al., 1996), and it is an essential explanatory mechanism underlying the emergence of unethical behaviors in employees' work scenarios; it also accounts for the effects of moral slippage. Specifically, UPB's unethical nature constitutes a grave breach of a person's internal moral standards, which can cause severe feelings of moral imbalance and self-condemnation. According to social cognitive theory, when people commit detrimental conduct that contradicts their ethical standards, they employ regulatory strategies, and moral disengagement is a suitable cognitive strategy for dealing with cognitive dissonance and preventing moral self-sanctioning (Bandura, 1999). Cognition leads to behavior, which in turn influences cognition. When the moral disengagement mechanism is activated by UPB, employees are released from the guilt associated with moral self-sanctions, and they are more inclined to act unethically in the future

(Detert et al., 2008). One fundamental driver of human social activity is the pursuit of self-interest, and unethical cheating frequently coexists with self-interested goals. An employee's prior unethical behavior catalyzes the eventual deployment of self-serving cheating once the morality valve has been opened. Thus, after UPB has undermined self-regulation systems through moral disengagement, employees who deceive customers for the benefit of the company can also engage in workplace cheating for their own benefit.

Additionally, the fact that individual characteristics contribute dramatically to cognitive, affective, and self-regulation processes has been confirmed (Wheeler et al., 2013), and interventions in individuals' beliefs may determine whether they engage in unethical behavior (Bratton & Strittmatter, 2013). Psychological entitlement, as an individual belief, has a notable effect on cognition, and highly entitled individuals usually exhibit a self-serving attributional disposition and feel unconstrained by rules (Harvey & Martinko, 2009). These entitled persons are willing to morally disengage from any ethical failure and are more successful at extricating themselves from ethical dilemmas at work (Lee et al., 2017). Consequently, employees who exhibit an entitlement mindset tend to be more cognitively receptive to UPB, which prompts them to morally disengage and act in immoral ways. Thus, as shown in Fig. 1, psychological entitlement is included as a moderator in our model.

Unethical pro-organizational behavior and moral disengagement

The term "UPB" refers to the actions taken by employees to benefit their organization or team members and promote functional effectiveness; however, these actions are contrary to societal values and ethical norms, and UPB generally results in concealment and misrepresentation (Umphress et al., 2010; Umphress & Bingham, 2011). Although UPB exhibit both immoral and pro-organizational characteristics, such behavior is nevertheless unethical in nature and may cause substantial harms to external stakeholders (Zhang et al., 2022). Accordingly, what are the effects and repercussions of UPB for actors? According to social cognitive theory, individuals are commonly capable of moral self-regulation, and their conduct is monitored and appraised under certain intrinsic moral criteria (Bandura, 1999, 2002) such that, if their behavior conflicts with moral norms, they are condemned by their own conscience. Thus, after committing UPB, the immorality of this behavior causes some employees to experience cognitive dissonance and negative moral emotions such as guilt or shame (Umphress & Bingham, 2011).

To reduce this cognitive disequilibrium, employees rationalize and provide justifications for these ethical failures. An important mechanism underlying this process is the reconstruction of their recognition of UPB, that is, the process of neutralization (Zsolnai, 2016). Cognitive restructuring is initiated by another crucial trait of UPB, i.e., pro-organizational intent, which is similar to organizational citizenship behavior. Employees may view UPB as a way of contributing to the organization, thus creating a meritocratic mentality. This view might be highly disorienting for employees and can easily overcome an individual's moral vigilance (Martin et al., 2014), leading to a loss of alertness to ethical issues and inducing a cognitive restructuring of unethical behavior. The reconstruction of the individual's cognition concerning a given behavior is itself instrumental with regard to triggering disengagement practices (Bandura, 1999).

More specifically, some cognitive mechanisms weaken the effects of the system of moral self-regulation and monitoring that exist within individuals, and individuals become inclined to behave in unethical ways when the self-regulatory function of this system fails—a process which has been described as moral disengagement from the social cognitive perspective (Bandura, 1999; Bandura et al., 1996). The triggering of employees' cognitive dissonance by UPB might result in the cognitive reconstruction of unethical actions to render acceptable, but this process degrades the individual's ethical standards and enhances the individual's acceptance of immoral acts, which could prompt the emergence of moral disengagement. Despite the good intentions underlying UPB, this kind of workplace deviance can erode employees' internal standards (Zhang et al., 2022), thus causing them to become morally disengaged as a strategy to cope with the discomfort they experience after engaging in UPB. Thus, we propose that UPB can motivate individual moral disengagement:

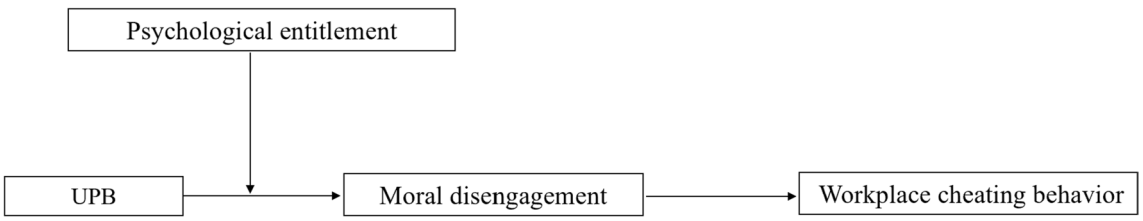


Fig. 1 The hypothesized model

Hypothesis 1: Employees' UPB is positively correlated with moral disengagement.

Moral disengagement and workplace cheating behavior

The term "moral disengagement" refers to a series of interconnected cognitive tactics and mechanisms that help people separate themselves from moral self-regulation to prevent the moral self-sanction caused by misconduct (Bandura, 1999; Ogunfowora et al., 2022). This notion also entails that the range of permissible behaviors for employees widens as they become more morally disengaged, and they may thus engage in more unethical behavior (Bandura et al., 1996; Shu et al., 2011). For instance, Shu et al. (2011) claim that moral disengagement permits cognitive systems to invalidate moral self-regulation such that individuals may tend to commit dishonest acts. We contend, therefore, that workers who experience moral disengagement due to UPB are more likely to favor their self-serving interests over others' interests in terms of their work behavior since they can both cheat customers for the benefit of the organization and cheat their leaders and colleagues for selfish purposes due to their ambiguous moral standards (Zhang et al., 2022). Consequently, such employees might indulge in deception, lying, and fraud to advance their interests in the workplace – actions that Mitchell et al. (2018) categorized as workplace cheating behavior.

Cheating by employees in the workplace has been identified as a deviation from moral norms and defined in terms of the use of deception to gain an unfair advantage for oneself or to obtain benefits to which one is not otherwise entitled (Farasat et al., 2020; Mitchell et al., 2018). Immorality, self-interest, and intentionality define such cheating activity (Mitchell et al., 2018). Thus, employees who engage in deceptive behavior pursue their own interests with little regard for whether their behaviors have a detrimental effect on their peers and organizations (Hillebrandt & Barclay, 2022). Given the detrimental effects of such cheating, organizational scholars have focused on the factors that predispose individuals to such behavior and have identified performance pressure as the major contributor to cheating conduct at work (Kundro et al., 2023; Mitchell et al., 2018). Several negative emotional experiences, such as wrath, humiliation, or shame, are also vital triggers that motivate cheating to various degrees (Hillebrandt & Barclay, 2022; Kundro et al., 2023). Notably, cheating behaviors are considerably affected by unethical factors, and when employees experience the anxiety associated with performance pressures, they often exhibit a lack of concern for ethics and morality, thereby engaging in cheating for self-serving purposes (Kouchaki & Desai, 2015).

In light of the preceding analyses, we suggest that moral disengagement may encourage employees to engage in workplace cheating behavior since employees who are accustomed to moral disengagement are less inclined to consider ethical standards and are less attentive to the repercussions of their acts for others (Bandura, 1999), a situation which is consistent with the traits of workplace cheating behavior (Hillebrandt & Barclay, 2022). Thus, employees who prioritize themselves and ignore ethical issues are more inclined to employ cheating tactics at work:

Hypothesis 2: Moral disengagement has a positive effect on workplace cheating behavior.

The mediating role of moral disengagement

From the perspective of social cognitive theory, Bandura et al. (1996) identified the concept of moral disengagement as grounded in the ineffectiveness of self-regulatory mechanisms. Social cognitive theory suggests that moral self-regulatory mechanisms exist within individuals that can encourage positive behaviors and inhibit detrimental behaviors that are contrary to intrinsic moral criteria (Bandura, 1999, 2002) because properly functioning self-regulatory mechanisms cause the individuals who engage in transgressive behaviors that conflict with their ethical standards to experience guilt and self-condemnation (Zhang et al., 2019). When the self-regulatory system becomes nonfunctional, individuals use the psychological mechanism of moral disengagement to rationalize their immoral conduct, which makes them more likely to behave unethically. Three categories of cognitive mechanisms by which individuals can exhibit moral disengagement have been identified. The first such category focuses on the individual's cognitive reconstruction of their own unethical behavior, which makes such behavior acceptable through means such as moral justification, palliative comparison, and euphemistic labels. Second, individuals can motivate moral disengagement by concealing or distorting the detrimental effects of such misconduct, such as by diffusing responsibility or ignoring harmful consequences. Finally, individuals can achieve moral disengagement by being less empathetic toward victims, including by dehumanizing them or attributing blame to them (Bandura, 1999; Zhang et al., 2019). Therefore, moral disengagement can invalidate the individual's self-regulatory function in the three ways listed above. However, individuals usually refer to previous acts as benchmarks for their subsequent conduct (Bandura, 1991); accordingly, once the moral valve is opened, individuals might commit further unethical acts.

Based on the preceding analysis, this study views moral disengagement as a mediator in its investigation of why employees continue to engage in workplace cheating behavior after having committed UPB. Specifically, in addition

to the process of cognitive reconstruction described above, employees may obscure or distort the destructive effects of UPB, ignore the harms to external stakeholders and society caused by UPB, and be less empathetic to customers who have suffered losses due to UPB, thereby activating the mechanism of moral disengagement (Moore et al., 2012). The deactivation of the monitoring and moral self-regulatory mechanisms could ultimately contribute to employees' tendency to disregard the unethical aspects of UPB, and the pro-organizational characteristics of such behavior allows employees to regard the short-term organizational profits to which UPB leads as their contribution, resulting in a reward-seeking mentality. Moreover, moral disengagement enables this immoral act to serve as a reference that causes some employees' work misconduct to be viewed as morally permissible. Given the blurred moral boundaries and reward-seeking mindset that result from this situation, cheating behavior is accepted by employees as an appropriate strategy for advancing their interests or obtaining returns. Thus, we propose the following hypothesis:

Hypothesis 3: Moral disengagement mediates the relationship between UPB and workplace cheating behavior.

The moderating role of psychological entitlement

Although UPB may inspire moral disengagement, which might trigger employees' cheating behavior at work, we contend that not every employee experiences the same effects due to UPB and that some employees do not become morally disengaged from their acts (Keem et al., 2018). Whereas external factors (e.g., performance pressure and workplace ostracism) are nonnegligible triggers that encourage employees to engage in workplace cheating behaviors, internal individual beliefs and convictions intervene to determine whether a given employee engages in cheating (Farasat et al., 2020). Psychological entitlement, as an internal belief, may intervene strongly in the destructiveness of UPB with regard to individual moral self-regulation (Wheeler et al., 2013). Thus, this study incorporates psychological entitlement as a critical variable that distinguishes individuals from one another.

The term "psychological entitlement" describes an ingrained and pervasive internalized belief that encourages individuals to perceive themselves consistently as deserving of privileges and preferential awards, frequently with little consideration for performance outputs or genuine contributions (Harvey & Martinko, 2009). A person who exhibits high psychological entitlement is often self-centered and has an inflated self-perception, valuing rewards over their contributions. Highly entitled workers, who experience a sense of superiority over other members of the organization, believe that they are more valuable than other employees and that they deserve privileges and acknowledgment in the work environment (Farasat et al., 2020). In contrast, employees who exhibit less psychological entitlement are better able to appropriately assess their performance and work environment (Wheeler et al., 2013). These less entitled individuals are more socially responsible and less inclined to behave unethically; they thus tend to experience less interpersonal conflict at work (Campbell et al., 2004; Grubbs & Exline, 2016; Zitek & Schlund, 2021).

The cognitive attributes of highly entitled employees may dramatically reinforce the impairing effects of UPB on their intrinsic moral standards. First, employees with higher psychological entitlement are extremely sensitive to punishments and rewards from their organization and are concerned about personal gains and losses (Campbell et al., 2004). UPB causes such employees to sacrifice their ethical standards; thus, they exhibit an even stronger aspiration for reciprocation and are more prepared to transgress their moral obligations with the goal of obtaining those privileges and rewards (Farasat et al., 2020), which can entail that moral disengagement is more easily activated by UPB. Second, individuals who exhibit high psychological entitlement also tend to exhibit comparably low levels of empathy, perspective taking, and respect for others at work and to be more selfish in their interpersonal relationships. All of these cognitive attributes are similar to the mechanisms that trigger moral disengagement, thus suggesting that entitled individuals are inclined to behave unethically (Harvey & Martinko, 2009). Compared to highly entitled employees, individuals with low levels of psychological entitlement have a well-developed sense of social responsibility and empathy (Campbell et al., 2004; Zitek & Schlund, 2021) and are in a better position to identify UPB as potentially detrimental to stakeholders outside the organization (Umphress et al., 2010), thus entailing that the degree to which moral disengagement is activated by immoral acts is decreased among such employees. Therefore, we propose the following hypothesis:

Hypothesis 4: Psychological entitlement moderates the relationship between UPB and moral disengagement such that the positive relationship between UPB and moral disengagement is stronger when employees exhibit high levels of psychological entitlement.

Moderated mediation model

Our development of a moderated mediation model was guided by the preceding analysis, which identifies moral disengagement as a mediating variable in the relationship between employees' UPB and workplace cheating behavior. The relationship between UPB and moral disengagement is moderated by psychological entitlement, and the positive

influence of employees' UPB on moral disengagement is stronger when employees exhibit high levels of psychological entitlement. Additionally, in our opinion, psychological entitlement moderates the indirect impacts of UPB on cheating behavior via moral disengagement. When workers experience a stronger sense of psychological entitlement, UPB has a greater influence on moral disengagement. Consequently, moral disengagement has a stronger mediating effect on the relationship between UPB and workplace cheating behavior. Thus, we formulate the following hypothesis:

> Hypothesis 5: Psychological entitlement moderates the indirect relationship between employees' UPB and workplace cheating behavior via moral disengagement such that this indirect relationship is stronger when psychological entitlement is high than when it is low.

Materials and methods

Participants and procedure

We collected data for the theoretical hypothesis tests from participants using an online questionnaire. In the present investigation, a total of 400 eligible participants were enrolled via the Credamo platform (which operates in a manner comparable to Amazon Mechanical Turk or Qualtrics) and invited to complete an online questionnaire that focused on unethical behavior at work and their subsequent cognitions and behaviors. Most of the organizations for which these participants worked were located in Guangdong, Jiangsu, and Jiangxi Provinces, China. The participants worked in the following industries: manufacturing, wholesale and retail trade, and software and information technology services. In addition, to ensure that they conformed to the study's goals, participants were required to satisfy the following conditions: they must have behaved in a manner that conflicted with social and ethical norms to further their organization's interests during the past month of their working time and describe the scenario in detail; they must be full-time employees of a business or company; and they must have high expectations of organizational rewards and compensation. We collected the questionnaires anonymously and distributed the questionnaires through an online platform that exhibits a certain degree of confidentiality to alleviate participants' concerns and mitigate the impact of issues pertaining to social desirability bias. This study was conducted at the individual level, and self-assessment was used to collect data because UPB is associated with a pro-organizational intent and is difficult for others to perceive and observe (Chen et al., 2016). Additionally, the unethical nature of UPB leads to a certain degree of concealment of this behavior on the part of employees.

In this study, a three-wave questionnaire was used to test the theoretical model. At time point 1 (March 8, 2023), the first wave of data collection was conducted, and all questionnaires were completed within one day. We emphasized the facts that the research was voluntary and anonymous and that its objectives and process aimed to encourage participants to complete the questionnaire conscientiously. A total of 400 online questionnaires were disseminated, and 345 valid samples were obtained after invalid samples were removed. Each participant received US $0.74 as a reward. At this point in the survey, we required participants to provide basic details, including their gender, age, educational record, employment history, and job position; we also collected data on the independent variable, i.e., UPB. At time 2 (March 23, 2023–March 28, 2023), the researchers administered 345 online questionnaires to the participants who provided valid responses at time 1, and 279 of these participants returned valid questionnaires. Each participant earned US $0.75 in payment. We collected questionnaires concerning the core variables of moral disengagement and psychological entitlement at this time. At time 3 (April 15, 2023–April 20, 2023), 279 questionnaires were sent to participants via the internet. In the final analysis, the researchers retained 257 valid questionnaires, and each participant received a reward of US $1.25. At this time, the collection of survey data regarding workplace cheating behavior was completed. Considering sample size selection and concerns regarding sufficiency, we drew on the experience of previous studies that have suggested that factor analysis requires a participant-to-item ratio of approximately 10:1 (Paillé & Boiral, 2013; Tinsley & Tinsley, 1987). This study includes a total of 20 items pertaining to the four core variables, suggesting that the number of participants required was 200. The fact that our actual sample size was 257 suggests that the sample size chosen for this investigation was appropriate.

Males accounted for 40.9% of the final sample, while females accounted for 59.1%. The age distribution was as follows: 14.4% of the sample was between 18 and 25 years old, 37.4% was between 26 and 30 years old, 36.2% was between 31 and 35 years old, 6.2% was between 36 and 40 years old, and 5.8% was 41 years of age or older. With regard to their educational background, only 2.3% of the respondents had only a high school education, 7.0% had completed junior college, 71.6% had earned a bachelor's degree, and 19.1% had earned a master's degree or higher. Regarding occupational tenure, 4.7% of respondents had worked at their current job for less than a year, 34.2% had done so for between one and five years, 45.1% had done so for between six and ten years, and 16.0% had done so for more than ten years. General employees accounted for 42.4% of the participants, followed by grassroots managers (21.0%), middle managers (26.9%), and senior managers (9.7%).

Measures

The scales used in this study were all drawn from authoritative and well-regarded journals. Three organizational behavior scholars translated the scales from their original English versions into Chinese, after which they were translated again into English. The use of this back-translation methodology enabled us to avoid culturally based misunderstandings. In this study, a five-point Likert scale was used, with 1 indicating strongly disagree and 5 indicating strongly agree.

Unethical pro-organizational behavior

We employed the 6-item scale developed by Umphress et al. (2010) to measure the UPB of employees. An example item is "If it would benefit my organization, I would withhold negative information about my company or its products from customers and clients." The Cronbach's alpha for UPB was 0.808.

Psychological entitlement

Employees' psychological entitlement was measured using the 4-item scale developed by Yam et al. (2017). An example item is "I honestly feel that I'm just more deserving than others." The Cronbach's alpha was 0.936.

Moral disengagement

Moral disengagement involves various potential concepts and mechanisms; thus, researchers must distinguish among the mechanisms underlying moral disengagement in different scenarios. The current study's goal was to measure the psychological status of employees who exhibit moral slippage in response to an unethical stressful event. Accordingly, to measure the moral disengagement of employees, we employed the 3-item scale developed by Chen et al. (2016). An example item is "To protect the interests of my business, it would be acceptable to withhold potentially damaging information." The Cronbach's alpha was 0.890.

Workplace cheating behavior

The 7-item scale developed by Mitchell et al. (2018) was utilized to assess the workplace cheating behavior of employees. A sample item is "Made up an excuse to avoid being in trouble for failing to complete work." The Cronbach's alpha was 0.917.

Control variables

This study's findings are likely affected by demographic factors to a considerable extent. Consequently, this study relied on prior research experience (Kish-Gephart et al., 2010) and included age, gender, educational background, occupation tenure, and job position as control variables. More precisely, males were coded as 1, while females were coded as 0. The age range 18–25 years was coded as 1, the range 26–30 years was coded as 2, the range 31–35 years was coded as 3, the range 36–40 years was coded as 4, and the range of 41 years and older was coded as 5. A high school diploma or below was labeled as 1, a junior college education was labeled as 2, a bachelor's degree was labeled as 3, and a master's degree or more was labeled as 4. Occupational tenure of less than a year was coded as 1, 1–5 years was coded as 2, 6–10 years was coded as 3, and more than 10 years was coded as 4. The code for general employees was 1; grassroots managers were assigned a code of 2, middle managers a code of 3, and senior managers a code of 4.

Analysis and results

Confirmatory factor analysis

Using AMOS 27.0 software, we conducted confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) to examine the discriminant validity of our four factors: UPB, psychological entitlement, moral disengagement, and workplace cheating behavior. Compared with the alternative models, the baseline four-factor model (theoretical model) exhibited a better fit with the data, as is apparent from the CFA results ($\chi 2/df = 1.860$, CFI = 0.959, TLI = 0.951, RMSEA = 0.058, SRMR = 0.049), thus demonstrating the excellent discriminant validity of the four core variables included in this study (see Table 1).

Common method bias

To minimize the potential impact of common method bias (CMB) on the study's findings, data collection was conducted at three times, with a two-week gap included between each data collection session. However, as CMB may impact employee self-reports, we employed SPSS 25.0 software for the present study. The results imply that the first factor explains only 23.79% of the overall variation, i.e., less than 50% of the total variance (70.03%). This finding demonstrates that our research is not affected by any significant CMB issues. In addition to the foundational model, we added a method factor (Podsakoff et al., 2003), and the relevant parameters exhibited changes of $\Delta\chi 2/df = -0.014$, $\Delta CFI = 0.004$ $\Delta TLI = 0.001$ $\Delta RMSEA = -0.001$ $\Delta SRMR = -0.011$, where the variation in CFI, TLI, and RMSEA was below 0.02 (see Table 1). Therefore, issues pertaining to CMB had little impact on our study.

Table 1 Results for confirmatory factor analysis

Model	$\chi 2$	df	$\chi 2$/df	CFI	TLI	RMSEA
Four factors	293.884	158	1.860	0.959	0.951	0.058
Three factors	1187.575	167	4.823	0.809	0.782	0.122
Two factors	1235.830	169	7.313	0.680	0.640	0.157
One factor	2055.196	170	12.089	0.435	0.368	0.208
Four factors + CMV	265.771	144	1.846	0.963	0.952	0.057

One factor: UPB + PE + MD + CHEAT. Two factors: PE UPB + CHEAT + MD. Three factors: UPB + CHEAT PE MD. Four factors: UPB PE MD CHEAT. Five factors: UPB PE MD CHEAT CMV. UPB is unethical pro-organizational behavior. PE is psychological entitlement. MD is moral disengagement. CHEAT is workplace cheating behavior

Descriptive analysis

The variables included in the research were subjected to a descriptive statistical analysis using SPSS 25.0. The means, standard deviations, and relationships among the selected core and demographic variables are presented in Table 2. The essential variables, including UPB, psychological entitlement, moral disengagement, and workplace cheating behavior, exhibit means (standard deviations) of 3.07 (0.859), 3.11 (1.275), 3.02 (1.189), and 2.40 (1.068), respectively. Specifically, a significant positive relationship between UPB and moral disengagement is demonstrated by the findings ($r = 0.188$, $p < 0.01$). Additionally, UPB and workplace cheating behavior are significantly positively correlated ($r = 0.345$, $p < 0.01$). Moral disengagement and workplace cheating behavior are significantly positively correlated ($r = 0.328$, $p < 0.01$). Psychological entitlement is positively correlated with moral disengagement ($r = 0.406$, $p < 0.01$). The hypotheses presented in this study are preliminarily supported by these findings. Overall, these associations do not indicate any unexpected findings.

Hypothesis testing

To test the hypotheses, a hierarchical regression analysis was performed using SPSS 25.0, and the bootstrap method was utilized to evaluate the mediating and moderating effects proposed in the present study (see Table 3). According to Hypothesis 1, UPB is positively correlated with moral disengagement. The results of the regression analysis including the control variables, including employees' gender, age, educational background, work tenure, and job position, are shown in Model 2, which indicates a significant positive correlation between employees' UPB and moral disengagement ($\beta = 0.233$, $p < 0.01$), consistent with Hypothesis 1. Furthermore, Model 7 demonstrates that workplace cheating behavior is positively and significantly influenced by moral disengagement ($\beta = 0.282$, $p < 0.01$), thereby supporting Hypothesis 2. Integrating Hypotheses 1 and 2, these two prerequisites provide evidence indicating that the mediating effect proposed in this study is valid.

According to Hypothesis 3, the relationship between an employee's UPB and their workplace cheating behavior is mediated by moral disengagement. As shown in Model 8, the positive impact of UPB on workplace cheating behavior decreases but remains significant when both employees' UPB and moral disengagement are included in the regression equation ($\beta = 0.355$, $p < 0.01$). Additionally, workplace cheating behavior is still positively impacted by personal moral disengagement ($\beta = 0.239$, $p < 0.01$). We performed a bootstrap test to examine the significance of this mediating effect with the goal of investigating the mediating

Table 2 Result of variable descriptive analysis

Variables	Means	SD	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
1. Gender	0.41	0.493	1								
2. Age	2.52	1.008	-0.050	1							
3. Education	3.07	0.592	-0.077	0.014	1						
4. Tenure	2.72	0.784	0.000	0.829**	-0.023	1					
5. Position	2.04	1.041	0.098	0.386**	0.052	0.377**	1				
6. UPB	3.07	0.859	0.161**	-0.138*	-0.094	-0.081	0.009	1			
7.PE	3.11	1.275	0.105	-0.131*	-0.113	-0.135*	0.202**	0.181**	1		
8. MD	3.02	1.189	0.081	-0.132*	0.000	-0.042	-0.122*	0.188**	0.406**	1	
9. CHEAT	2.40	1.068	0.073	-0.138*	-0.166**	-0.139*	-0.185**	0.345**	0.251**	0.328**	1

**$p < 0.01$, *$p < 0.05$

Table 3 Result of hierarchical regression analysis

Variables	Moral disengagement				Workplace cheating behavior				
	M1	M2	M3	M4	M5	M6	M7	M8	M9
Gender	0.193	0.137	0.125	0.087	0.163	0.064	0.109	0.031	0.026
Age	-0.324*	-0.283*	-0.262	-0.250*	-0.009	0.063	0.082	0.131	0.128
Education	0.043	0.071	0.164	0.154	-0.278*	-0.229*	-0.290	-0.246*	-0.213*
Tenure	0.346*	0.329*	0.463	0.453**	-0.107	-0.138	-0.205	-0.216	-0.166
Position	-0.127	-0.138	-0.293	-0.273**	-0.155*	-0.174**	-0.119	-0.141*	-0.191**
UPB		0.233**		0.158*		0.411**		0.355**	0.344**
MD							0.282**	0.239**	0.186**
PE			0.442**	0.424**					0.116*
UPB×PE				0.133*					
R^2	0.047	0.074	0.245	0.268	0.071	0.174	0.165	0.240	0.253
ΔR^2	0.028	0.051	0.227	0.245	0.053	0.154	0.145	0.219	0.229
F	2.470*	3.314**	13.511**	11.369**	3.839**	8.791**	8.238**	11.232**	10.521**

**$p < 0.01$, *$p < 0.05$

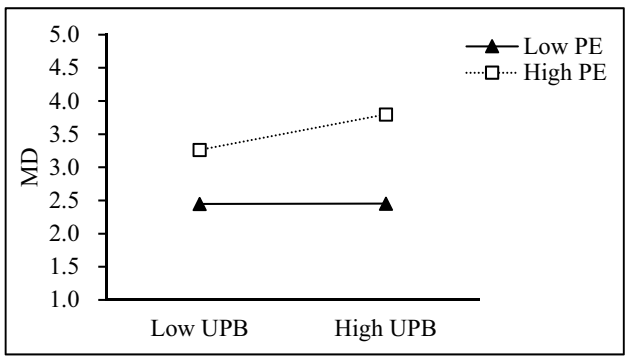


Fig. 2 Moderating effect of psychological entitlement on the relationship between UPB and moral disengagement

effect of moral disengagement on the relationship between employees' UPB and their cheating in further detail. The results suggest that UPB has a significant indirect impact on employees' workplace cheating through their moral disengagement (indirect effect = 0.056, SE = 0.026, 95% CI [0.014, 0.116]), thereby supporting Hypothesis 3.

Hypothesis 4 proposes that psychological entitlement moderates the relationship between UPB and moral disengagement. To investigate the moderating impact of psychological entitlement, the hierarchical regression method was used. The centralization of the variables in interaction terms prevented any issues with multicollinearity. Model 4 confirms that psychological entitlement significantly moderates the relationship between UPB and moral disengagement ($\beta = 0.133$, $p < 0.05$) and that moral disengagement is positively impacted by the interaction term. We used a conventional methodology and display the chart at both low (M − 1SD) and high (M + 1SD) levels of psychological entitlement to assess the orientation of the interaction term's effect. As depicted in Fig. 2, among employees with stronger psychological entitlement, a positive and stronger connection is observed between unethical behaviors that benefit the organization and moral disengagement. However, for employees who assess their psychological entitlement as low, this positive relationship is weaker. Thus, Hypothesis 4 is supported.

The assumption of the moderated mediation model in Hypothesis 5 is investigated using the bootstrap method with the assistance of the SPSS PROCESS program. The findings indicate that the indirect influence of employees' unethical pro-organizational behavior on their cheating in the workplace via moral disengagement is 0.0747, 95% CI [0.0214, 0.1557], in the context of personnel with high psychological entitlement (+ 1 SD). However, UPB's indirect influence on cheating at work via moral disengagement is 0.0008, 95% CI [− 0.0496, 0.0532] – a range that includes 0 – when psychological entitlement is low (− 1 SD). This finding suggests that, in contrast to workers with low psychological entitlement, workers with high psychological entitlement are more inclined to exhibit moral disengagement and to engage in the corresponding deviant work behaviors after engaging in UPB. Thus, Hypothesis 5 is supported. The outcomes are displayed in Table 4.

Discussion

Moral disengagement, which is grounded in social cognitive theory, serves as a mediator in the theoretical model, while psychological entitlement plays a moderating role. We conducted this study to improve our understanding of how employees' UPB affects their cheating behavior at work from the perspective of cognitive mechanisms at the individual level. In light of the findings revealed by the data analysis, which focused on a sample of 257 Chinese employees, we

Table 4 Results of the conditional indirect effects

Moderator variable	Moral disengagement		
	Boot indirect. effect	Boot se	95%CI
Low psychological entitlement (1 - SD)	0.0008	0.0256	[-0.0496, 0.0532]
High psychological entitlement (1+SD)	0.0747	0.0336	[0.0214, 0.1557]

conclude that (1) the mediating effect of employees' psychological process of moral disengagement on the relationship between employees' UPB and cheating behavior is verified; (2) with regard to the three distinct categories of cognitive mechanisms, UPB can activate an individual's moral disengagement, thereby undermining the individual's internal system of moral monitoring and self-regulation and causing them to engage in unethical cheating behaviors; (3) differentiation at the level of employees' psychological entitlement leads to varying degrees of moral disengagement; and (4) UPB's indirect impact on employees' cheating in the workplace through moral disengagement is strengthened by psychological entitlement. In the following, this paper discusses the theoretical and practical implications of these findings as well as the deficiencies of the current research and prospective paths for future research.

Theoretical contributions

The literature on UPB and workplace cheating behavior is enriched by our efforts in several ways. First, the current research contributes new content to the UPB literature by analyzing the connection between workers' UPB and workplace cheating behavior and revealing the potential moral slippage effect of this unethical behavior (Anderson et al., 2023). In contrast to previous studies of the after-effects of UPB at the individual level, which have focused primarily on positive outcomes, such as organizational citizenship behavior and voice behavior (Tang et al., 2020; Wang et al., 2021a, b), this study found that employees' UPB might lead to ineffective moral self-regulation, thus triggering cheating behavior. Thus, this paper challenges conventional wisdom, arguing that UPB is an unbeneficial or even destructive behavior. In this process, a critical link lies in the fact that the cognitive reconstruction triggered by UPB weakens employees' monitoring and regulating capabilities regarding immoral conduct. This conclusion corresponds with social cognitive theory, which suggests that individuals tend to act unethically when their cognitive mechanism leads to an impaired capacity to self-regulate (Bandura, 1999; Bandura et al., 1996). Therefore, this study provides a new theoretical perspective on the impact of workers' UPB on their cheating behaviors and broadens the domains in which social cognitive theory can be applied.

Second, the present research contributes to the ethics literature by investigating the potential mechanisms underlying the association between employees' UPB and their workplace cheating behaviors. Moral disengagement is considered to be a significant cognitive process that encourages people to behave unethically (Lian et al., 2020). Zhang et al. (2022) claimed that moral disengagement plays a mediating role in the process underlying employees' tendency to commit immoral acts and subsequent engagement in counterproductive work behaviors. Our findings draw an analogous conclusion that supports the argument that the association between UPB and workplace cheating is mediated by moral disengagement. While it has been shown that an individual who behaves immorally becomes more immoral in terms of his or her behavior over time (Anderson et al., 2023), social cognitive theory's introduction of the mediating role of moral disengagement improves our understanding of the cognitive processes that characterize people who become trapped in this type of moral slippage, thus allowing us to examine the antecedents of cheating behaviors from the perspective of unethical triggers and cognitive mechanisms rather than merely in terms of the pressure of performance or self-protection (Kundro et al., 2023; Mitchell et al., 2018). Finally, the findings of our study illustrate the fact that the connection between pro-organizational and proself unethical behavior can be explained by moral disengagement.

Third, as discussed, employees' UPB is related to their workplace cheating, and moral disengagement explains this association. However, the mediating effect of moral disengagement might vary based on differences in individual characteristics, and not all employees behave in an unethical manner after engaging in UPB (Wang et al., 2021a, b). Given the pro-organizational character and "contributivity" of UPB, we examined how highly entitled employees who exhibit an inflated sense of self behave after engaging in UPB. Our findings reveal that the significant correlation between employees' UPB and moral disengagement is stronger for individuals with high psychological entitlement than for individuals with lower PE, and the mediating impact of moral disengagement is stronger in the former context. That is, we find that employees who feel more psychologically entitled are more likely to experience the psychological state of moral disengagement after abandoning their ethical code in pursuit of the organization's profit. These employees overestimate their contributions to their work and, as a

result, believe that they are more deserving of privileged treatment; they are thus inclined to advance their interests by engaging in unethical behavior (e.g., cheating). More specifically, psychological entitlement, as an individual characteristic, may worsen outcomes for both workers and organizations (Liu et al., 2022). According to Zhao et al. (2007), measures of such individual differences can expand theory in this context and make further contributions to the literature. Thus, our study enriches the literature on entitlement.

Practical implications

Our research has several practical implications regarding the management of UPB. In contrast to self-interested unethical behaviors, the initial motivation for UPB is to advance the interests of the organization, and UPB serves as a strategy that can help the organization achieve success in the short term, which makes this behavior somewhat disorienting (Fehr et al., 2019). Particularly in an intensely competitive commercial setting, workers find it difficult to adhere to moral principles, and organizational managers might adopt an attitude of acquiescence or encouragement toward employees' UPB – they may even personally participate in UPB (Babalola et al., 2020; Chen et al., 2016; Nguyen et al., 2021). For example, regarding the financial scandal that broke in April 2020, Luckin Coffee's COO, Jian Liu, fabricated financial growth of US $310 million in 2019 in an effort to help the company attract investors in a competitive market environment (Zhang et al., 2022).

However, our study suggests that UPB is not as beneficial to organizations as prevailing wisdom would claim. Employees' UPB triggers changes in individuals' cognitive and self-regulatory mechanisms, thus raising the possibility of those individuals engaging in self-interested unethical behavior at work. Namely, the moral valve may be opened when employees engage in UPB, thereby initiating the activation process of the cognitive mechanism underlying moral disengagement. Subsequently, moral disengagement, as a crucial cognitive process, can lead employees to engage in unethical, counterproductive, and cheating behaviors at work, which often cause immeasurable losses to their organization (Mitchell et al., 2018; Nguyen et al., 2021; Zhang et al., 2022). Therefore, the detrimental effects of UPB should be recognized by every organization. However, from a social cognitive perspective, employees' exposure to organizational policies and performance pressures in business practices is an influential factor with regard to UPB (Mo et al., 2022), and managers must contemplate how to eradicate business environment pressures and triggers that foster UPB at the organizational and institutional levels. First, as motivation guides individual behavior (Wang et al., 2021a, b), organizational management should take into account the fact that employees engage in UPB since it might have immediate advantageous impacts on the business; that is, the utilitarian goal of helping the organization succeed within a short period of time constitutes a major motivation for employees (Zhang et al., 2022). Thus, managers must formulate a long-term development scheme for organizations in a scientific and reasonable manner and establish a fair and transparent career promotion system (Nguyen et al., 2021) to resolve the contradiction between the organization's long-term goals and employees' short-term goals with the goals of cultivating employees' strategic awareness and avoiding short-term speculation, thus decreasing their motivation to engage in UPB. Second, even if UPB is performed with good intentions, organizational managers should clearly express a negative attitude toward this behavior to prevent employees from exhibiting blind loyalty to the organization; they should also implement a system of punishment to address such behavior (Lian et al., 2020).

Additionally, the current research indicates that moral disengagement, which is a psychosocial cognitive strategy, acts as a significant mediator of the relationship between UPB and workplace cheating behavior, such that the cognitive mechanism activated by UPB allows employees to avoid feeling morally obligated to act in a socially desirable manner (Bandura, 1991, 2002; Huang et al., 2017). Thus, the limitations of moral self-regulation should be considered by organizations, and managers should attempt to reduce the extent to which UPB results in moral disengagement (Huang et al., 2017). An ethical organizational culture and climate can be effective disincentives that can dissuade employees from exhibiting moral disengagement (Fehr et al., 2019), and organizations should highlight the importance of such a culture and concentrate on instilling ethical core values with regard to the organization (Farasat & Azam, 2020), such as by using seminars and training methods to enhance employees' ethical awareness and ethical sensitivity to prevent the rationalization of cheating through moral disengagement after employees have engaged in UPB. For managers, ethical leadership is effective with regard to discouraging employees' from exhibiting moral disengagement and preventing them from engaging in deviant behaviors (Moore et al., 2019). Thus, organizations should facilitate and reward managers in their attempts to exhibit ethical leadership, and managers should emphasize the importance of acting ethically through their leadership practices with the goal of encouraging employees to reflect on their ethical choices (Men et al., 2018) and reactivate their moral self-regulation, thereby decreasing the power of UPB and moral disengagement to generate deviant behaviors.

Finally, our study concluded that psychological entitlement has a detrimental impact that can increase employees' moral disengagement and exacerbate the moral slippery slope risk posed by UPB. Therefore, it is imperative for organizations and managers to be aware of whether

employees exhibit a sense of entitlement and to employ unique management practices to reshape employees' psychological entitlement perceptions (Priesemuth & Taylor, 2016). More specifically, organizations should establish a reasonable performance appraisal system to help employees benchmark their work objectives against their actual outputs and to help employees form objective judgments of the value of their workload, thus fostering a sense of fairness that can significantly reduce employees' psychological entitlement (Zitek et al., 2010). Furthermore, the pro-organizational nature of UPB might instill in those who engage in such behavior the mentality of "a meritorious minister", which could contribute to an increased sense of psychological entitlement. In response, organizations must establish a clear system of rewards and sanctions that incorporate ethical standards to ensure that employees do not become more psychologically entitled due to the sacrifice of their intrinsic moral values.

Limitations and directions for future research

The conclusions of the current study are supported by appropriate theoretical evidence and data analysis, but some limitations remain, which highlight directions for future research. First, in terms of the research design, a self-report questionnaire was utilized for data collection, thus making it difficult to prevent the effects of CMB. Therefore, a three-wave data collection process was implemented. The data analysis results demonstrate that CMB had no significant impact on this study; however, future research could employ a multichannel approach to data collection. Subsequently, in the process of constructing the theoretical model, with regard to the mediating effects is concerned, this study examined only the mediation of moral disengagement from a social cognitive perspective. However, this investigation of the potential mediating mechanisms through which UPB leads employees to engage in workplace cheating behaviors has not yet been sufficiently comprehensive. Future research could consider UPB as a workplace stressor and negative emotional variables as mediating factors in this context. In terms of moderating variables, only psychological entitlement, an individual belief, was included as a moderator in this study. Future studies could incorporate additional individual differential variables, such as moral identity and organizational ethical climate, as boundary conditions (Nguyen et al., 2021). Finally, based on previous experience, only typical demographic factors such as gender were taken into consideration in this study, and we did not take into account the impact of social desirability. Although anonymization was used, incomplete consideration of control variables remains a concern with regard to this research, which may affect the interactions among variables in the theoretical model. Future research could consider using scenario-based experiments to revalidate the theoretical model presented in this study.

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Data availability The datasets generated during and/or analyzed during the current study are publicly available, and we uploaded the data files to the Open Science Framework at https://osf.io/mscb9/.

Declarations

Ethical approval The studies involving human participants were reviewed and approved by the Ethics Review Committee of the School of Management, Harbin Institute of Technology, with the Statement Code No.202313.

Informed consent Informed consent was obtained from all individual participants included in the study.

Conflict of interest The corresponding author declares that there is no conflict of interest on behalf of all authors.

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